

S05-01 - Open Vale? Ritual Site

Player read-aloud

The trees stop all at once. Above you, the sky opens. Someone has installed a sign here, but the stones are much older than the words on it.

Scene summary

The party arrives at a perfect circular clearing older than its corporate name.

Visible choices

- Inspect stones
- Set perimeter
- Ask Custodian about past ritual

Player questions

- What detail in Open Vale? Ritual Site tells you the official story is incomplete?
- Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it?
- What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?

Raw source

- Id: S05-01
- Act: Act Five
- Title: Open Vale? Ritual Site
- Beats: Location focus Threshold / transition Lore reveal
- Image: assets/scenes/S05-01-open-valetm-ritual-site.png
- Short: The party arrives at a perfect circular clearing older than its corporate name.
- Long: Open Vale is sacred, dangerous, and branded after the fact. The air should feel too still.
- Read: The trees stop all at once. Above you, the sky opens. Someone has installed a sign here, but the stones are much older than the words on it.
- Gm: Emphasize that the place predates Goldspire. The brand is a sticker on a god's door.
- Entities: Open Vale? Ritual Site Keystone Asset Forgotten Gods The Stones of the Vale Whitefire Custodian Goldspire Territories Ritual Countdown Route Assurance Contract Marlowe Fairwind Sealed Keystone Crate
- Choices: Inspect stones Set perimeter Ask Custodian about past ritual
- Prompt: Circular forest ritual clearing with standing stones, old ward symbols, awkward corporate sign labeling Open Vale Ritual Site, sealed ward-stone at center; party arrives with Custodian; no strixwolf, no undead yet.
- Source Entities: Open Vale? Ritual Site Keystone Asset Forgotten Gods
- Beat Codes: location-focus threshold-transition lore-reveal
- Slug: S05-01-open-valetm-ritual-site

- Act Title: The Ward Renewal
- Arc Role: Ordeal, ritual defense, and restoration
- Caption: Open Vale is where the contract becomes a defense of living infrastructure.
- Image Alt: Open Vale? Ritual Site scene art for The Ward Renewal.
- Image Prompt Used: Circular forest ritual clearing with standing stones, old ward symbols, awkward corporate sign labeling Open Vale Ritual Site, sealed ward-stone at center; party arrives with Custodian; no strixwolf, no undead yet. Do not include the Strixwolf Mother, strixwolf pups, wolves, owlbeats, or animal companions unless explicitly requested. No Strixwolf. No Bramble Union. Only Legacy Security Skeletons and Soul-Audit Wraiths as threats. 4:3 cinematic fantasy concept art, no visible text, no captions, no logos, no UI, no watermark.
- Long Storyboard: Open Vale is sacred, dangerous, and branded after the fact. The air should feel too still. Run this scene as ordeal, ritual defense, and restoration: Open Vale is where the contract becomes a defense of living infrastructure. Keep the camera close to practical choices, visible consequences, and the difference between ordinary people and the infrastructure pressing on them.
- Read Aloud: The trees stop all at once. Above you, the sky opens. Someone has installed a sign here, but the stones are much older than the words on it.
- Gm Notes: Emphasize that the place predates Goldspire. The brand is a sticker on a god's door. Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it. Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic.
- Sensory Details: wet stone grass whispering in circles old runes clicking like cooling metal
- Body Language: The Custodian kneels before she commands anything Marlowe stops pretending the crate was just cargo
- Sample Dialogue: Whitefire Custodian When the light rises, anything the old system left unpaid may come to collect.
- Checks: Knowledge Read the ritual field and assign roles. Standard Better placement for countdown and defense. 15 Cleanly resolve: Read the ritual field and assign roles. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to Open Vale? Ritual Site. The full goal slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence. The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to tick the ritual countdown, expose the Custodian, activate ward backlash, or trigger Market Correction. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers: visible fact, actionable clue, then systemic truth.
- Choices Consequences: Protect the Custodian closely Fewer hits reach her. Strong ward more likely. Spread out for threats Better control of enemies. Custodian may be exposed.
- Clues: Ward geometry Protect the center. Legacy failures arrive through old obligation paths. The site is a network node, not a battlefield by design.
- Loot: Open Vale residue after the ritual Keystone Asset?: Inside the sealed crate, packed in wax-paper and reassurance, sits a heavy grey stone the size of a loaf, warm to the touch, faintly humming, with a light deep inside it that is slowly going out. Whitefire Custodian's Ward-Charm: A small hand-carved wooden ratcoon mid-

scamper has been thumb-worn smooth for luck. It is warm, and the forest feels a little kinder while you hold it.

- Payoff Flags: Ward Stability Track
- Filters: act-five choice gm-only location-focus lore-reveal the-ward-renewal threshold--transition ward-stability-track manufactured-threat guaranteed-earned clue
- Index: 18
- Player Questions: What detail in Open Vale? Ritual Site tells you the official story is incomplete? Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it? What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?
- Relationship Prompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownership Prompt: Name one detail in Open Vale? Ritual Site that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Reveal Hooks: Loreborne or Knowledge-focused PCs can read the institutional layer. Wildborne/community-focused PCs can read local custom and ecological stress. Martial/security-focused PCs can read threat posture and custody logic. Magic-focused PCs can feel ward tone, soul-signal, or spell instability. Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or ward-craft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress. Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage. Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.
- Fear Spends: Spend Fear to tick the ritual countdown, expose the Custodian, activate ward backlash, or trigger Market Correction. Tick the Ritual Countdown the wrong direction or expose the Custodian. Trigger Market Correction, Pass-Through, Memory Delve, or Group Attack when fiction supports it.
- Story Scope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit." REFLAVOR GUARANTEED A defeated wraith leaves a Soulspire compliance tag or coil-credit token instead of natural remains. ADD GUARANTEED Wraiths ignore forest creatures and home only on ritual soul-magic. ADD EARNED Instinct Medium 15 A player can read the markings and name Soulspire without the GM naming it first. ADD EARNED Knowledge Medium 15 Optional flag: Legacy Skeletons carry scraps of old corporate credentials. FLAG SEED Instinct: target logic. Knowledge: read markings. ACT5 Act 5: Open Vale defense 200 2:40 to 3:20 3:20 countdown 8, skeletons, wraiths, Market Correction Lower the countdown start to 6; cap wraith reinforcements.
- Mechanics: The party is in Act Five pressure: The party arrives at a perfect circular clearing older than its corporate name. Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting. s05-01-read-the-open-vale-pattern S05-01 Read the Open Vale pattern Read the Open

Vale pattern Knowledge Instinct Knowledge Instinct 14 Knowledge reads the circle; Instinct feels what the clearing excludes. The ritual starts without a clear defensive map. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The ritual starts without a clear...

- Roll Cards: s05-01-read-the-open-vale-pattern S05-01 Read the Open Vale pattern Read the Open Vale pattern Knowledge Instinct Knowledge Instinct 14 Knowledge reads the circle; Instinct feels what the clearing excludes. The ritual starts without a clear defensive map. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The ritual starts without a clear defensive map. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it costs time...
- Conditions Hazards: No official condition unless a feature, hazard, or fictional position calls for Hidden, Restrained, or Vulnerable.
- Search Loot Clues: Open Vale residue: ward sand, regrowth signs, cold seal wax, humming chip.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: Open Vale? Ritual Site asks what the party does, what it costs, and who is protected.
- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Instinct, Knowledge, Strength. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Location Ids: open-valetm-ritual-site the-stones-of-the-vale
- Item Ids: keystone-asset whitefire-ward-charm
- Clueids: route-assurance-contracttm public-private-ward-compact
- Clue Ids: route-assurance-contracttm public-private-ward-compact
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